



Two tones each — Direct for when you're low on energy, Softer for when you want cushioning. Nothing here has to be said word for word.

Cancelling plans

DIRECT

I need to cancel today — not up for it. Can we find another time?

SOFTER

I'm sorry, I need to step back from today. It's not about you, I just don't have it in me.

Asking for an accommodation

DIRECT

I work better with [written instructions / extra time / a quiet space]. Can we set that up?

SOFTER

Would it be alright if we tried [written instructions / extra time]? It genuinely helps me do better work.

Needing quiet or space

DIRECT

I need some quiet for a bit. I'll come find you after.

SOFTER

I hope this doesn't come across wrong — I just need a little space. I'll be back soon.

Explaining, after a hard moment

DIRECT

That was a shutdown, not me being rude. I needed to stop, not to upset you.

SOFTER

I owe you some context about earlier — my brain hit a wall and I couldn't keep going.

Asking someone to repeat

DIRECT

Can you say that again, slower? I lost the middle of it.

SOFTER

Sorry — could you go back a step? I want to take this in properly.

Saying no

DIRECT

That doesn't work for me. Thanks for asking though.

SOFTER

I've thought about it and I'm going to say no this time — but I appreciate you thinking of me.



Correcting a misread tone

DIRECT

My face doesn't always match what I mean. I'm not annoyed — I'm concentrating.

SOFTER

Sorry if that came out flat. I'm actually really interested, my expression just doesn't always show it.

Asking for instructions in writing

DIRECT

Could you send that in a message? I lose things said out loud.

SOFTER

Would you mind popping that in an email? It helps me get it right first time.

Leaving somewhere early

DIRECT

I'm going to head off now. It's been good — I've just hit my limit.

SOFTER

I'm going to slip away shortly. I've really enjoyed it, I just need to go before I'm running on empty.

Declining a phone call

DIRECT

Could we do this over text instead? Calls are hard for me.

SOFTER

Would text work? I process written things much better, and I'd rather give you a proper answer.

When plans change suddenly

DIRECT

I need a minute to adjust — I'd built the day around the old plan.

SOFTER

That's fine, I just need a moment to rearrange things in my head. Give me five and I'll be with you.

Disclosing, if you choose to

DIRECT

I'm autistic/ADHD. It mostly means [X], and [Y] helps.

SOFTER

There's something that might help you understand how I work — I'm [X], which mostly affects [Y].

You don't owe anyone an explanation. These are here for when you want one.